Google Ad Grant Plan

Oct 26, 2026

The Hutton gets up to $10,000 a month of free Google search ads. We use about half of it, mostly on traffic we don't need, and nobody has steered the account since May. With light, hands-on management it could work for philanthropy, events and venues, recruitment, the Innovation Centres and HSS.

Where we are

- **Spend:** $51,815 in the last 12 months (about $4,300 a month), rising to about $5,700 a month in October.
- **Where it goes:** half goes to one automated campaign. Over the past year, 72% of what we can see of it bought clicks on "pollen count today", mostly from people outside Scotland. Since the season ended it has moved on to soil maps, plus things like non-executive director jobs.
- **What it achieves:** we don't know. The only "conversion" tracked is a page view, which also puts our Ad Grant compliance at risk!
- **Who's steering:** Lane Media, but there's been one small set of changes since May. Google ads are normally tweaked several times per month to keep them optimised.
- **Who's missing out:** Everyone -
    - **Venue hire and the Immersive Suite:** about $430 a year. Our "immersive suite hire" keyword is one almost nobody types, while we paid $19 for a single click on "village halls for hire near me".
    - **Philanthropy:** Friends of Hutton and Tercentenary Circle keywords only went live this month, and no donation or supporter enquiry is tracked.
    - **Innovation Centres:** $159 across the whole year for APGC, IBH and NPIC combined. The Barley Hub seminar ad still counts down to April 2023.
    - **HSS:** $0 all year and just 15 impressions. People already search for PAS110, XRD and FTIR, but only find us by accident through the automated campaign.
    - **Events:** Fruit for the Future, Potatoes in Practice and the Macaulay Lecture campaigns are paused leftovers from past years. Meanwhile "What's on" pays for people looking for a night out in Aberdeen.

What's available

Roughly $50,000 to $70,000 a year of free search advertising is going unused. The grant allows $10,000 a month and we use $4,300 to $5,700.

The catch is that every ad must serve the Hutton's mission, and paid services must explain how the money supports our research. That suits our priorities well. Philanthropy, public events and knowledge-led content are exactly what the grant is designed for.

What we could achieve

Six audiences, in priority order, each with one real result to count. Priority means first call on the budget and always fully funded. Share follows how many people actually search, so a small share for philanthropy is about demand, not importance.

Priority	Audience	What the ads would do	Success we'd count	Starting share of grant
1	Philanthropy	Friends of Hutton, Tercentenary Circle, legacy and donation searches	Donations and supporter enquiries	10%
2	JHI events and venues	Public events, webinars, venue hire, Hutton Hub and Immersive Suite awareness	Event bookings, webinar sign-ups, venue enquiries	30%
3	Recruitment and PhDs	Live vacancies and studentships, aimed at relevant searches only	Job application clicks	20%
4	Innovation Centres	APGC, IBH and NPIC partnerships, facilities and news	Partner enquiries, newsletter sign-ups, service enquiries	20%
5	HSS	Knowledge-led content (soil, PAS110, XRD), soft fruit varieties, not-for-profit events like Fruit for the Future	Content downloads, event bookings, service enquiries, waitlist sign-ups	10%
6	Brand and general science	People searching for the Hutton, soil maps and other public resources	Visits to key pages (tracked, not counted as conversions)	10%

The shares are a starting point to agree, not a fixed carve-up. They're easy to move month by month.

A quick win hiding in the data: people already search for Hutton-bred fruit varieties, plus honeyberries and PAS110. We're catching them by accident today. A proper campaign would catch them on purpose.

What needs to be done

Fix the foundations. The set-up takes roughly 3 to 5 days, then about 4 to 8 hours a month to run.

1. **Foundations (November)**
    - Move the admin login to a hutton.ac.uk account and remove old users.
    - Track real results (bookings, enquiries, applications, donations) and stop counting page views.
    - Decide who runs it: in-house, the agency, or a one-off agency clean-up handed over to us.

2. **Rebuild (December to January)**
    - Set up one campaign per audience in the table above.
    - Rein in the automated campaign and block irrelevant searches.
    - Add "profit reinvested in research" wording to HSS and venue hire pages.
3. **Ready for spring (February to March 2027)**
    - Launch 2027 event and webinar campaigns.
    - Start a monthly one-line report to each stakeholder showing what their share delivered.

Next steps:

Tell us what success looks like. Each team names the one action that matters most: a donation, a booking, a venue enquiry, a job application or a service enquiry.

Where do you want the ad to land? Every ad needs a page with one clear next step – book, enquire, request a quote, donate, apply.

Agree priorities and starting share. See table above. Review after 3 months.

Agree how to measure. Monthly update?